C1 Writing

Writing a proposal

Persuade a decision-maker with a clear, well-organised proposal that states the problem, the plan and the benefits.

A proposal looks like a report, with headings and a formal tone, but its purpose is different: it looks to the future and tries to persuade. The reader should finish it knowing exactly what you suggest and why it is worth doing.

Section	Content	Useful language
Introduction	Purpose of the proposal	*The aim of this proposal is to suggest ways of…*
Current situation	The problem, with evidence	*At present, many staff report that… According to a recent survey,…*
Proposal	Concrete, practical steps	*I would propose that… One option would be to… This could be achieved by…*
Benefits	What will improve	*This would not only… but also… The main advantage would be…*
Conclusion	Summary and call to action	*I am confident that these measures would… I would welcome the opportunity to discuss…*

Use the conditional. Proposals describe something that does not exist yet, so *would* and *could* are natural: *This would reduce costs.* They also sound polite rather than demanding.

Common mistake. Vague suggestions such as *We should improve communication.* Be specific: who will do what, when, and roughly at what cost: *A monthly ten-minute team update would be introduced from January.*

Practice

You are writing a proposal to your manager to improve staff wellbeing.

1. Write the first sentence of the introduction.
2. Describe the current situation using evidence.
3. Make the vague suggestion specific: We should help people exercise more.
4. State a benefit using "not only... but also".
5. Write a closing call to action.

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. The aim of this proposal is to suggest practical ways of improving staff wellbeing.
2. At present, over half of employees say they feel stressed, according to last month's staff survey.
3. For example: The company could offer free twice-weekly fitness classes in the meeting room after work.
4. This would not only reduce sick days but also improve morale.
5. I would welcome the opportunity to discuss these ideas with you in more detail.